‘Then we can play off one against another,’ Singh said. ‘There will be some battles lost but our focus is on tactical victory. We need to identify and engage with allies in Fiji if we plan to defeat and dismantle the military regime and get the Indians out of this nightmare scenario.’

Meanwhile, Rabuka made another shocking move. In a discussion with his army colleagues, the military ruler strongly favoured the possibility of deporting all ethnic Indians back to India. The band realised the importance of a political antidote. They pushed a top rung Indian leader in the Fiji Labour Party, one of their prized assets, to lead the party. Adi Bavadra, widow of Timoci Bavadra, had been controlling it since the death of the deposed leader in 1989. It took a couple of months and a spectacular operation from Sydney to win over the opponents of the Indian asset in the party. All sorts of ammunition were used to garner support for her. Once the Fiji Labour Party decided to appoint the Indian asset as its chief, the long and daring spy operation was called off and the band returned to Delhi.

Post-script

In Delhi, the band was now limited to desk jobs. In the vocabulary of espionage, they had been told to spend some time in the cold. But Malik, Singh and Sahgal continued to devote long nights reading cables from Sydney. Rabuka was turning democratic. In June 1991, he accepted the leadership of a new political outfit called Soqosoqoni Vakavulewani Taukei. He announced that elections would be held in 1992. Despite massive rigging by the military regime, Rabuka’s party won only thirty out of seventy seats in parliament. As he desperately sought support from other parties to form the government, the